

Connectivity-wise all three phones here featured Bluetooth—something that is mandatory for cellphones in this category. Pretty much all the cell phones across the three sub categories had Bluetooth as a connectivity option, with most vendors doing away with IR, Sony Ericsson phones still feature both options however.

Conclusion

This was the most exciting category, and we actually had to sub-divide it, because of the sheer variety available.

The first mini battle takes place at the bottom of the group, (price-wise), where the Nokia 7360 emerges winner, battling it out with its older sibling the 6600, (which is really showing its age now), and the Motorola E398. Youth and beauty win here, as the 7360 really makes a fashion statement for itself.

The second group sees the Sony Ericsson K750i emerging as winner, expandability, excellent cam and MP3 playback, compactness, this phone has it all, at Rs 14,995, we feel it's a really good deal. The Samsung X700 comes in a decent second, with the two Nokia's just nipping at its heels.

In the top segment, price-wise, the N70 is head and shoulders above the competition, providing a very good camera, clear, loud MP3 playback and all the functionality you're likely to need. Samsung's D600 takes second place, but if you have a budget of around Rs 20,000, we really recommend the N70, simply because of the gamut of features it brings to the equation.



Siemens ME75

MID-RANGE PHONES

If your budget is important, but not the only thing influencing your buying decision, and you need a decent feature-set as well, this is the section of phones you will be looking at!

With looks ranging from 'fairly decent' to 'good' you can actually think of gifting these to a near and dear one. The price band we have chosen is broad—from Rs 5,500 to Rs 10,000. Here again we will split this category, this time into two, below and above Rs 7,500.

Rs 5,500 to Rs 7,000

Phones in this segment are characterised by a VGA camera which also shoots videos at a standard QCIF (Quarter Common Intermediate Format) resolution of 176 x 144. All of them have USB connectivity, for synchronising of contacts and transferring images or video. Additional device-to-device connectivity is in the form of Bluetooth on the Motorola L6 and the LG C2500, while the other phones make do with infrared. Bluetooth offers higher speeds than infrared can, and does not depend on line-of-sight transfers.

Internet connectivity is via GPRS on all phones here—the Nokia 6020 deserves special mention for offering EDGE and HSCSD (High Speed Circuit Switched Data). All phones have a WAP 2.0 and XHTML compatible browser. The browser on the C2500 was the slowest amongst the lot, while the L6 was fast—as fast as navigating through the rest of the phone.

PIM and Contact Management

All phones provide a scheduler where you can set reminders for a particular date and time, and you can also attach a note here. So, equal

Nokia N91

Nokia's answer to the 'Walkman' branded phones from Sony Ericsson comes in the form of N91. Combining some bleeding edge technologies and support for various music formats, the N91, definitely packs the bang to take down its opponents.

Encased in a stainless steel body the phone feels sturdy and solidly put together; however, keeping it spotlessly clean can be a challenge. While the design isn't special, this candy bar phone does seem a little longer than most phones.

The N91 is the first phone to integrate a 4 GB hard drive and thus has the capacity to store a significant chunk of one's music collection. With dedicated buttons for music playback along with an intuitive user interface, the N91 can go toe-to-toe with any MP3 player in the market. Nokia has also integrated a standard 3.5 mm stereo jack into the phone, allowing most headphones to be connected without an adapter. Support for music format includes MP3, AAC, WMA, and MP4. The included stereo headset provides decent quality but there is definitely room for improvement. Transferring music is just a matter of drag and drop as the phone is detected as a USB drive under Windows XP.

As it should be with most music phones, the music capability is well synergised in the phone. Automatic pausing of music when a call comes and subsequent playback on ending the call speaks for the amount of thought put in.

The 262k colour display is brilliant; only to be spoiled by an acceptable, but not great, resolution of 176 x 208. The keypad is exposed by sliding down the media controls. Its keys are too

small for comfort and those with fat fingers will definitely have problems operating the pad.

Speaking of other features this is probably the first phone from Nokia to integrate Wi-Fi 802.11g. Other connectivity options include Bluetooth 1.2 and USB 2.0. The phone also supports EDGE and hence browsing over GPRS is blazing fast.

The N91 also integrates a 2 megapixel camera capable of clicking shots up to 1200 x 1600. It can also record video in MPEG4, H.263 and RealVideo8 formats. The shots taken were good and match up to those offered by competitors.

Priced at Rs 33,999 the Nokia N91 is one of the most expensive music phones around. Considering the 4 GB hard drive, Wi-Fi 802.11g, stainless steel body and other notable features the price tag might seem appropriate but for most of us, it's still too expensive.

+ 4 GB hard drive
- Cramped keypad
Rating: 3.5/5



Lifestyle Phones